

Dennis G. Pezan

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EDUCATION

B.S., Operations Research – Finance Specialization

Class of 2029

United States Military Academy (USMA), West Point, NY

Minor in Artificial Intelligence

GPA 3.586

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Reinforcement learning, reward design and misspecification, ensemble methods, predictive modeling under uncertainty, autonomous systems, military operations research

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Reward Misspecification in a Simulated Multi-Echelon Resupply Task

Summer 2026

Research Intern, Modeling & Analysis Division, Transformation Decision Analysis Center (TDAC), U.S. Army, Fort Lee, VA

- Engineered and iteratively redesigned the reward function for a reinforcement learning agent operating in the Army's Logistics Battle Command (LBC) simulation
- Diagnosed reward hacking through behavioral auditing, rebuilt the objective, and verified the correction against the original failure modes
- Trained and evaluated the agent in Python (PyTorch) against a new implementation of the LBC environment, analyzing how reward design shaped learned policy behavior

Applied Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning Research

2025–Present

Undergraduate Research Assistant, Department of Mathematical Sciences, USMA (advisor: MAJ Patrick Kuiper)

- Conduct applied AI and ML research on model behavior and data-driven decision making
- Developed Python pipelines (PyTorch, scikit-learn) to train and benchmark reinforcement learning and ensemble models
- Automated experiment tracking and visualization to accelerate research iteration

Variance Reduction in Tree-Based Ensemble Classifiers

Spring 2026

Course research project, MA289, USMA

- Trained and evaluated Decision Tree, Bagging, and Random Forest classifiers on an identical 80/20 split of the Titanic dataset in Python (scikit-learn)
- Computed pairwise tree correlation empirically ($\rho \approx 0.76$ bagging vs. 0.67 random forest) to demonstrate how decorrelation lowers the irreducible variance floor
- Built and deployed an interactive research site presenting the methodology and results

TECHNICAL REPORTS

Not peer reviewed.

Pezan, D. G. (2026). *Diagnosing and correcting reward misspecification in a simulated multi-echelon resupply task.*

Technical brief. dennis-pezan.com/rl-reward-paper.html

PRESENTATIONS

MA289 Research Presentation, USMA, West Point, NY

Spring 2026

Decision trees and ensemble methods: variance reduction through tree decorrelation

D. G. Pezan

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Cadet Ambassador

2025–Present

CLD-STEM / Cadet Ambassador Program, USMA

- Represent West Point at advisory boards in Chicago and Los Angeles

Elected Alderman and Township Supervisor

June 2024

Illinois Premier Boys State

- Elected to municipal and township office; advanced to the Lieutenant Governor primary through competitive public speaking

SERVICE AND OUTREACH

Academic Tutoring

2025–Present

Certified Tutor, Center for Enhanced Performance (CEP), USMA

- Provide tutoring in mathematics, chemistry, and psychology, supporting cadets in mastering core concepts and exam preparation

STEM Outreach and Mentorship

2025–Present

Cadet Ambassador, CLD-STEM, USMA

- Delivered STEM outreach and mentorship to underrepresented students (50+ hours)

Technology Access Initiative

Jan – July 2024

Volunteer Senior Publicist, Recycle & Reboot, Plainfield, IL

- Led outreach to secure donated technology; helped refurbish and distribute 100+ computers to underserved communities

HONORS AND AWARDS

Stokes Writing Fellowship, USMA

2025–Present

Dean's List, USMA (both semesters)

26-1, 26-2

Norwegian Foot March Badge

2026

TECHNICAL SKILLS AND COURSEWORK

Programming: Python (PyTorch, scikit-learn, pandas, NumPy, matplotlib), Java (Spring Boot), SQL

Tools: Git and GitHub, Vercel, Microsoft Fabric, Kafka, REST APIs, Excel

Coursework: MA289 (Machine Learning), MA371 (Linear Algebra)

Languages: Spanish (fluent)

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Department Manager, McDonald's

Sept 2022 – July 2024

Plainfield, IL

- Managed weekly scheduling for 80+ employees with 95% on-time accuracy; oversaw \$20,000+ in weekly supply procurement and operations
- Promoted as the youngest department manager in the region at age 16; sustained 90%+ customer satisfaction

Intern, GrayStone AI Solutions

June – July 2024

Remote

- Built Python and Excel tools supporting financial planning and analysis workflows